

Road to Connivance: Common Knowledge, Inverted Charity, and the Evolutionary Stability of Clientelistic Populism

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Abstract

This paper develops an integrated theoretical framework combining Pinker's common knowledge dynamics, Maimonides' charity hierarchy (inverted), and multilevel evolutionary game theory to explain the persistence of clientelistic populism despite observable welfare losses. When governments publicly announce non-enforcement of property rights while maintaining visible redistribution programs, they create common knowledge that enables coordinated norm collapse. This dynamic inverts Maimonides' ladder of charity: anonymous market transactions are stigmatized as "speculation," while public subsidies, even when undelivered, sustain electoral coalitions through hope rather than outcomes. I propose self-service clientelism as a conceptual framework describing a zero-cost extended phenotype where the state achieves redistribution via strategic omission, allowing occupants to extract resources directly from owners while the state bears no fiscal cost.

Empirically, I analyze four contemporaneous cases (2020, 2026): Argentina's 420% surge in housing usurpations, Chile's 31% increase in informal settlements under Boric, Mexico's one million occupied INFONAVIT homes under Sheinbaum, and Spain's okupación epidemic under Sánchez. Despite differences in institutional quality and GDP per capita, all four exhibit identical causal sequences: ex ante public announcements create common knowledge of non-enforcement, asymmetric targeting prevents property owner coordination, and occupant coalitions consolidate through state toleration. External validation via Sowell's historical cases (Malaysia, Uganda, Argentina, Nigeria) suggests this pattern may be evolutionarily stable across diverse contexts when property rights enforcement is weak.

The framework yields testable predictions for 2026, 2030: continued occupation growth despite policy corrections, formal rental supply contraction, housing deficit persistence, and eventual government-led legalization of occupations rather than eviction. Policy implications require simultaneous intervention at three levels: restoring common knowledge via public enforcement rituals, reversing charity hierarchy inversions through voucher systems favoring anonymous market transactions, and eliminating asymmetric targeting to enable property owner collective action.

Keywords: Common knowledge, clientelism, evolutionary game theory, property rights, housing policy, norm collapse, extended phenotype

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I. Introduction

On September 21, 2020, approximately 2,500 families occupied vacant land in Guernica, Argentina, erecting makeshift homes within 48 hours while police stood by under instructions not to intervene. Television coverage broadcast the occupation nationwide. Within weeks, similar invasions emerged across Greater Buenos Aires. By 2025, usurpation cases had increased 420% compared to pre-pandemic levels, while prosecution rates remained near zero. What began as a COVID-19 emergency measure had transformed into a stable equilibrium where everyone knew that everyone knew the state would not defend property rights.

This is not an isolated phenomenon. Between 2022 and 2026, three additional cases emerged across Latin America and Europe that replicate the same pattern under different institutional contexts. Chile experienced a 31% increase in informal settlements despite President Boric's promise of 260,000 new homes. Mexico's new president openly declared "we will not evict anyone" while conducting a census of one million occupied homes financed by federal mortgage agencies. Spain's government suspended evictions for landlords owning three or more properties, triggering a 7.4% annual increase in okupaciones while 40,000 public housing units sat empty.

These cases share a puzzle that existing literature on clientelism, populism, and property rights cannot fully explain. Why do governments adopt policies that simultaneously destroy

housing supply, generate visible welfare losses for identifiable victims, empower criminal organizations, and persist despite electoral competition? Traditional political economy models predict that bad policies should be selected against when voters can observe their consequences. Yet across four countries spanning developed and developing economies, left-wing coalitions have consolidated power precisely by tolerating property rights violations.

I argue that this persistence plausibly reflects the interaction of three mechanisms that, when combined, may constitute an evolutionarily stable strategy. First, following Pinker's analysis of common knowledge, public announcements of non-enforcement transform private expectations into coordinated norm collapse. When "everyone knows that everyone knows" the state will not evict occupants, individual calculations shift from "will I be evicted?" to "everyone else is occupying, so I should too." This is not mere information transmission; it is the creation of common knowledge as a coordination device.

Second, this dynamic inverts Maimonides' eight-level hierarchy of charitable giving. In Maimonides' framework, the highest form of charity is anonymous assistance that enables self-sufficiency, while the lowest is public giving accompanied by expectations of recognition. Contemporary clientelistic regimes systematically reverse this ordering: private rental markets (anonymous transactions) are stigmatized as "speculation," while government housing promises, even when undelivered, sustain electoral support through visible commitment rather than actual outcomes. The inversion transforms charity from a poverty-reduction mechanism into a dependency-creation mechanism.

Third, I propose the concept of self-service clientelism as a zero-cost extended phenotype. Unlike traditional clientelism where the state extracts resources via taxation and redistributes them to beneficiaries, this variant achieves redistribution through strategic omission of enforcement. Occupants extract resources directly from property owners while the state bears zero fiscal cost, maintains plausible deniability ("we merely failed to enforce, we did not expropriate"), and captures electoral benefits from grateful occupants who believe the state is protecting them.

These three mechanisms combine within a multilevel evolutionary game theory framework. At the individual level, occupants face Nash equilibria where occupation becomes rational once common knowledge of non-enforcement is established. At the group level, occupants

form cohesive coalitions sustained by state subsidies and criminal networks, while property owners fragment due to asymmetric targeting (first “large landlords,” then smaller owners). At the institutional level, between-group selection favors jurisdictions practicing connivance over those practicing enforcement, as occupants outnumber and are more geographically concentrated than property owners in key electoral districts.

My empirical strategy combines within-case process tracing (Argentina 2020, 2025) with cross-case comparison (Chile, Mexico, Spain 2022, 2026) and external validation via historical precedents documented by Sowell (2015). I suggest that the Pinker-Maimonides-EGT synthesis generates testable predictions about occupation growth rates, supply responses, housing deficit evolution, and policy trajectories. Preliminary evidence indicates these predictions appear consistent across countries with vastly different institutional quality: Spain’s rule-of-law index (0.71) is 69% higher than Argentina’s (0.42), yet both exhibit the same causal sequence; only the rate varies.

My contribution is threefold. First, I attempt an integration of common knowledge theory (Pinker) with clientelism research, exploring how public announcements may function as coordination devices that lock in norm collapse. Second, I propose that Maimonides’ charity hierarchy, inverted, offers a parsimonious account of why clientelistic coalitions persist despite visible welfare losses: visibility itself may sustain the coalition rather than the outcome. Third, I conceptualize self-service clientelism as a potentially distinct form of redistribution that achieves state objectives without fiscal costs, and explore its stability relative to traditional clientelism.

II. Theoretical Framework

II.A. Economic Microfoundations: Sowell’s Perverse Incentives

Thomas Sowell identifies a critical threshold in redistributive systems: when benefits for poverty exceed wages from formal employment, the implicit tax rate surpasses 100%. A recipient earning €1,000 per month in benefits who could earn €900 per month in formal employment faces an effective tax rate of 111% on labor income. Working costs them €100 net of benefits foregone.

This mechanism operates at the micro level but generates macro consequences through two pathways. The direct pathway aggregates individual rational responses into institutional collapse: when enough individuals choose benefits over work, labor force participation drops, the formal sector contracts, and property rights security erodes as informal occupation becomes economically superior to formal rental. The mediated pathway involves politicians exploiting this dynamic to construct dependent voting constituencies. Bureaucracies expand through census rituals that enumerate beneficiaries, creating common knowledge of the state's "generosity" while justifying budget increases. The culmination is redistributive clientelism that locks in across electoral cycles.

Spain exemplifies this dynamic. The 2026 suspension of evictions for owners with three or more properties creates an implicit subsidy for occupation: okupas save €800, 1,200 monthly in Madrid's rental market, equivalent to formal employment earnings for many. With 16,426 okupación cases reported in 2024, this represents an annual wealth transfer of approximately €157, 236 million from property owners to occupants, entirely off the public budget.

Mexico's trajectory is more dramatic. President Sheinbaum inherited 845,000 occupied INFONAVIT homes and 90,000 FOVISSSTE homes. Her April 2025 announcement ("we will not evict anyone; we will find solutions for all families currently occupying these homes") transformed occupants' expected tenure from precarious to quasi-permanent. If the average INFONAVIT mortgage payment is \$3,000 pesos monthly, the implicit subsidy totals approximately \$2.5 billion pesos annually, borne by INFONAVIT's balance sheet rather than the federal budget.

Chile's case demonstrates the mediated pathway. Boric's "Plan de Emergencia Habitacional" promised 260,000 homes while proclaiming "no desalojos sin solución habitacional." Between 2022 and 2024, campamentos grew 31% to 1,432 settlements housing 120,584 families. Yet only 30,000, 40,000 housing units were delivered (11, 15% of the target). The gap between promise and delivery sustains the coalition: occupants believe housing is forthcoming and vote accordingly, while bureaucracies expand to administer the unfulfilled program.

Sowell's insight, that implicit tax rates above 100% create rational poverty traps, extends beyond labor markets to property markets. When the state suspends enforcement asymmetrically,

it imposes an implicit tax on property ownership while subsidizing occupation. The subsidy's magnitude (rental value saved) often exceeds potential formal earnings, creating a rational equilibrium where occupation dominates employment-seeking. Property rights insecurity then feeds back into housing supply: investors withdraw capital, construction declines, deficits widen, and the cycle perpetuates.

II.B. Pinker: Common Knowledge and Coordination

Steven Pinker's analysis of common knowledge provides the mechanism by which individual perverse incentives cascade into collective norm collapse. Common knowledge differs from mutual knowledge in a crucial respect: it is not merely that everyone knows X, but that everyone knows that everyone knows X, and everyone knows that everyone knows that everyone knows X, ad infinitum. This infinite regress creates a qualitatively different social fact; it enables coordination where mutual knowledge alone cannot.

Pinker illustrates with the hypothetical Super Bowl advertisement. If a company announces during the Super Bowl that "tomorrow, everyone should wear blue," viewers know two things: they heard the message, and millions of others heard it too. Each viewer knows that other viewers know that still other viewers heard it. This common knowledge enables coordination: individuals wear blue not because they personally prefer it, but because they expect others will, and they want to coordinate. The advertisement creates a focal point that would not exist from private communication alone.

In the housing cases I analyze, governments' public announcements function as Super Bowl advertisements for occupations. When Argentina's President Fernández decreed COVID-19 eviction moratoria in March 2020 via nationally televised address, he created common knowledge that the state would not enforce property rights. Potential occupants did not merely learn the policy; they learned that everyone else learned it, that property owners learned that occupants learned it, and that police learned that both owners and occupants learned it. This infinite mutual knowledge transformed occupation from a risky individual gamble into a coordinated mass strategy.

Chile's Boric made the mechanism even more explicit during his 2021 campaign, promising "no evictions without housing solutions" in televised debates watched by 5 million

viewers (28% of Chile's population). When 10,000 people occupy Cerro Centinela in San Antonio, they do so with common knowledge that everyone knows the state will not act. Judicial eviction orders remain unexecuted for three years not because the state lacks capacity, but because common knowledge has created a coordination equilibrium where enforcement would trigger a crisis that "everyone knows" the government wishes to avoid.

Spain's 2026 announcement that landlords with three or more properties cannot evict occupants created an especially pernicious form of common knowledge. Potential okupas now know: if they target landlords with three or more properties, they are safe from eviction; they can identify such landlords via public registries; other okupas know this too; landlords know that okupas know this. The result is targeted occupation campaigns. Barcelona recorded 5,077 okupaciones in 2024 alone, 30.9% of Spain's national total. Common knowledge concentrated attacks on the subset of property owners explicitly denied state protection.

Mexico's April 2025 census announcement by INFONAVIT director Romero Oropeza ("this will allow us to offer the best solution; we will not evict anyone"), followed by house-by-house enumeration of one million occupants, combines Pinker's mechanism with Sowell's perverse incentives. The census is a public ritual that creates common knowledge of both the occupants' existence and the state's tolerance. Occupants know they have been counted but not evicted, inferring permanent toleration. New occupants observe this and join, knowing they too will be tolerated.

The stability of these equilibria derives from common knowledge's self-reinforcing nature. Once established, reversing common knowledge requires costly signaling: the government must publicly, visibly enforce evictions in ways that create new common knowledge ("the state now enforces property rights"). Half-measures fail: selective evictions that are not publicized do not destroy the common knowledge of non-enforcement; they merely create common knowledge that "bad luck befell those specific occupants." Only large-scale, televised evictions accompanied by presidential statements can shift the equilibrium.

Pinker's framework explains why institutional quality (rule of law, GDP per capita) delays but does not prevent norm collapse once common knowledge mechanisms are triggered. Spain's rule-of-law index (0.71) is 69% higher than Argentina's (0.42), yet both exhibit identical

dynamics, merely at different speeds. Common knowledge operates as a coordination technology that appears relatively insensitive to institutional quality. A weak state in Argentina and a strong state in Spain both seem to lose effectiveness once they publicly announce non-enforcement, because the announcement, rather than underlying state capacity, may be the critical variable creating the common knowledge that enables occupation.

The common knowledge mechanism, however, operates bidirectionally. Governments create common knowledge enabling occupation through public announcements of non-enforcement; media ecosystems simultaneously create common knowledge inhibiting reversal through synchronized catastrophist framing of any reform attempt. A companion study of Argentina's February 2026 labor reform (Lerer 2026c) documents how Argentine and Spanish media, without coordination, produced structurally identical narratives within 48 hours of Senate approval: *Pagina 12*, *El Pais*, *La Sexta*, and *ElDiario.es* all framed a reform whose provisions largely mirror existing Spanish regulation as catastrophic regression. In 4 of 5 regulatory dimensions, the Argentine reform proposed rules equal to or stricter than Spain's current law; yet media coverage in both countries amplified the single differential element (the Austrian-style severance fund) while distorting shared elements (in-kind payment limits of 20% in Argentina versus 30% in Spain were presented as novel threats). This narrative isomorphism suggests media function not as external observers but as extended phenotypes of an institutional memeplex that perceives reform as a threat to its own reproduction (Dawkins 1982). The bidirectional lock-in helps explain why connivance equilibria persist even when electoral alternation produces governments nominally committed to property rights enforcement: the media channel creates common knowledge that reform is "politically toxic," raising the reputational cost of reversal beyond what most politicians will bear.

II.C. Self-Service Clientelism: Taxation by Omission

Traditional redistribution follows a three-stage sequence: compulsory extraction via taxation, centralized reallocation through budgets, and targeted transfers through social programs. This process is visible, costly, and politically contentious. Each stage creates opposition: taxpayers resist extraction, fiscal conservatives oppose deficits, and non-beneficiaries question fairness. The state bears full administrative and political costs while beneficiaries capture gains.

Self-service clientelism inverts this structure. The state achieves redistribution through strategic omission of enforcement, allowing occupants to extract resources directly from property owners. The three stages become: omission of enforcement (the state suspends evictions), decentralized extraction (occupants self-appropriate rental value), and random incidence (owners absorb losses). This structure has several advantages over traditional clientelism.

First, fiscal cost is zero. Spain's Casa 47 holds 40,000 public housing units that could theoretically house 50% of the country's estimated 80,000 okupas. Constructing these units cost the state approximately €100,000 each (€4 billion total). Maintaining them empty while okupas occupy private properties transfers the housing cost to private owners: a subsidy of €2.4, 3.6 billion annually if okupas would otherwise pay €800, 1,200 monthly rent. The state captures electoral benefits from okupas who believe the government is "protecting" them, while bearing zero fiscal cost.

Second, moral framing is powerful. Traditional welfare programs can be attacked as "subsidizing laziness" or "dependency culture." Self-service clientelism frames occupants as victims of "speculation" by "large landlords" or "vulture funds." Spain's government explicitly targets "grandes tenedores" (large landlords), creating moral permission for okupación. Chile's Boric stigmatized landowners resisting campamentos as "preferring speculation to social housing." Argentina's Peronist coalition portrays usurpation as "workers reclaiming land stolen by oligarchs." This framing is far more resilient to political attack than direct transfers.

Third, irreversibility is high. Once occupants establish residence, physical removal becomes traumatic. Courts in all four countries increasingly recognize "de facto possession" as creating equitable claims, especially when occupants have children in local schools or occupancy exceeds two years. Traditional welfare can be eliminated via legislation; self-service clientelism creates facts on the ground that are expensive and politically dangerous to reverse.

Fourth, electoral lock-in is permanent. Recipients of cash transfers can spend benefits anywhere, limiting geographic concentration. Occupants are immobile, tied to the occupied property. This creates stable, geographically concentrated voting blocs in key districts. Barcelona (5,077 okupaciones) is a PSOE-Sumar stronghold. Buenos Aires Province (source of 65% of

Argentina's usurpations) is Peronism's electoral base. Chile's Valparaíso (+118 new campamentos, 2022, 2024) is Boric's coalition heartland.

This logic extends into the penal realm through toleration of juvenile delinquency and property crimes. When the state systematically omits prosecution of usurpations (0% in Argentina, 2020, 2025) or leaves eviction orders unexecuted (eight Chilean judicial orders affecting 14,000+ people, September 2025), and when legislators refuse to lower the age of penal imputability despite evidence of organized networks using children under twelve as criminal agents, the state does not merely redistribute via omission: it effectively creates de facto “paraestatal collection agents” analogous to legal tax withholding agents.

Occupants and juvenile offenders act as decentralized collectors of an uncodified “tax” on property owners and crime victims, transferring value toward clientelistic policy beneficiaries without visible fiscal cost or administrative responsibility. This extension of the state's extended phenotype through willful omission generates international liability under the Velásquez Rodríguez doctrine: the state responds not for the illicit act itself (occupation, theft), but for “lack of due diligence to prevent the violation or address it as required” by international human rights conventions. The result is a hybrid system where state coercion operates through strategic omission, delegating resource extraction to private agents whom the state tolerates, protects, and in some cases electorally incentivizes.

Game-theoretic formalization clarifies the equilibrium conditions. Let $e \in [0,1]$ represent enforcement effort and p represent occupation probability. The state maximizes:

$$V(e) = N \cdot p(e) \cdot R - C_e \cdot e - C_p \cdot [D - N \cdot p(e)]$$

where $N \cdot p(e)$ equals the number of occupants (increasing as enforcement e decreases), R denotes electoral reward per occupant, $C_e \cdot e$ represents cost of enforcement, C_p equals cost of public housing provision per unit, D is the housing deficit, and $D - N \cdot p(e)$ captures the deficit not covered by private okupación. The first-order condition $dV/de = 0$ yields optimal enforcement $e^* < 1$ (under-enforcement) when $R > C_p$; that is, when electoral reward per occupant exceeds the cost of providing public housing. This inequality holds in all four cases.

Self-service clientelism may thus approximate an evolutionarily stable strategy when property owners are fragmented (cannot coordinate), occupants are concentrated (can coordinate via common knowledge), and moral framing favors “vulnerable” over “speculators.” The state’s extended phenotype operates at zero fiscal cost, maximum political benefit, and minimal reversibility: a dominant strategy equilibrium.

II.D. Multilevel Evolutionary Game Theory

Within-Group: Asymmetric Targeting Prevents Coordination. In all four cases, governments initially target a subset of property owners, creating heterogeneity that prevents collective action. Spain’s “three or more properties” rule explicitly exempts small landlords, who initially supported the policy believing themselves protected. When enforcement delays affected them too (93% of small landlords report inability to evict under current regulations), they lacked organizational infrastructure to resist; large landlords had already been stigmatized and neutralized.

Argentina’s Ley de Alquileres 27.551 (2020) included tax incentives for “small owners” who registered contracts, splitting the landlord coalition. By the time usurpations surged in 2020, 2022, small landlords discovered exemptions were illusory (courts applied “vulnerability” criteria regardless of landlord size), but fragmentation prevented unified resistance.

Meanwhile, occupant groups maintain cohesion through three mechanisms. State subsidies (Argentina’s Potenciar Trabajo, Chile’s housing promises, Mexico’s INFONAVIT census) create common interests. Criminal organizations (Los Trinitarios in Chile, narcos in Villa 31 Argentina, emerging cartel control in Mexico) provide selective incentives: protection from rival occupants, assistance with utility connections, mediation with authorities. Common knowledge enables coordination: occupants know others will not voluntarily leave (creating mutual assurance), while property owners face prisoners’ dilemmas (each owner prefers others resist while they individually settle).

Between-Group: Electoral Selection Favors Connivance. *At the jurisdictional level, between-group selection appears to favor coalitions practicing connivance over those practicing enforcement. Connivance coalitions, governments that tolerate occupations while maintaining*

visible social programs, capture electoral support from numerically superior and geographically concentrated occupants. Enforcement coalitions, governments that evict occupants and defend property rights, suffer electoral punishment from displaced occupants and their sympathizers.

Argentina demonstrates this starkly. Peronist governors in Buenos Aires Province (Axel Kicillof), Santa Fe, and Chaco tolerated usurpations post-2020, receiving electoral support from over one million plan beneficiaries plus occupants. Kicillof won re-election in 2023 despite a 300% increase in usurpations under his administration. Non-Peronist governors in Mendoza and CABA who attempted evictions faced violent resistance, national media criticism (“government evicts vulnerable families”), and electoral costs.

Spain’s dependence on Cataluña and País Vasco further illustrates the point. PSOE-Sumar governs nationally only with support from ERC, Junts (Catalan separatists), and PNV (Basque nationalists). Cataluña accounts for 40% of Spain’s okupaciones and 16% of population; okupas are over-represented 2.5 to 1 in Cataluña relative to the national average. ERC and Junts demand rent controls and anti-eviction protections as conditions for supporting PSOE budgets. Sánchez complies because losing Catalan support would collapse his government.

Cultural Evolution: Norm Inversion and Memetic Diffusion. At the cultural level, Maimonides’ charity hierarchy inverts through repeated public rituals. Each government housing announcement, census of occupants, or televised debate about “vulnerable families vs. speculators” reinforces the inversion: public charity with maximum visibility (government promises, even undelivered) becomes morally superior to anonymous market transactions (private rentals). This inversion spreads memetically across jurisdictions.

Argentina pioneered the pattern post-2001 and cemented it between 2020 and 2025. Chile observed and adapted via Boric’s campaign (2021), explicitly modeling Argentine piquetero movements. Spain imported the framing wholesale: “grandes tenedores” mirrors Argentine “fondos buitres” (vulture funds); “viviendas vacías” echoes Argentine “especulación inmobiliaria.” Mexico’s Morena party draws ideological inspiration from Argentine Peronism and Chilean Frente Amplio, completing cross-border memetic transmission.

Sowell (2015) documents identical historical patterns: Malaysia’s Bumiputera policies (50-year clientelistic dependence), Uganda’s 1972 expulsion of Asians (property redistribution to

politically connected elites), Nigeria's post-colonial ethnic redistribution (fueling civil war). The mechanism (public announcements creating common knowledge, charity hierarchy inversion, between-group selection favoring connivance) appears recurrent across diverse cultural contexts and potentially stable once property rights enforcement is weak.

Media coverage patterns provide additional evidence of memetic diffusion. When Argentina's Senate approved labor reform on February 12, 2026, Spanish media produced quantitatively disproportionate coverage: *El Pais* published three articles in 48 hours (versus one on Denmark's 2024 reform), *La Sexta* devoted a 12-minute prime-time segment (versus zero on Chile's 2023 reform). The coverage intensity is consistent with what evolutionary theory would predict: if Argentina (CLI 0.87) successfully reforms, Spain's argument that "reform is impossible" loses credibility, threatening the memeplex's reproductive fitness in Spain (CLI 0.51). Catastrophist coverage of Argentine reform functions as immunization: it raises the reputational cost of proposing similar changes domestically, validates existing resistance, and constructs narrative precedent for future use. This is not conspiracy; it is the spontaneous defensive response of a shared institutional memeplex operating through its extended phenotypes across borders (Lerer 2026c).

The multilevel synthesis offers a parsimonious account of persistence: within-group fragmentation hinders property owner resistance, between-group selection rewards connivance coalitions electorally, and cultural evolution reinforces norm inversion through memetic diffusion across jurisdictions and time periods. Institutional quality delays onset but cannot prevent lock-in absent simultaneous intervention at all three levels.

III. Empirical Strategy

My empirical approach combines three complementary methods to test the Pinker-Maimonides-EGT framework: within-case process tracing of Argentina (2020, 2025) as the primary case, cross-case structured comparison of Chile, Mexico, and Spain (2022, 2026) as contemporary replications, and external validation via Sowell's historical cases (Malaysia, Uganda, Argentina, Nigeria) as temporal and geographic extensions.

Within-Case Process Tracing: Argentina 2020, 2025. Argentina serves as the primary case because it provides the longest time series (five years post-intervention), the most dramatic outcome (420% increase in usurpations), and the most complete documentation of the causal chain from public announcement (March 2020, DNU 320/2020) through common knowledge creation (Guernica mega-usurpation, September 2020, televised nationally) to stable equilibrium (0% prosecution rate, 12% judicial resolution rate by 2024). I trace the mechanism through archival analysis of presidential decrees, legislative debates, judicial rulings, and media coverage.

Cross-Case Comparison: Chile, Mexico, Spain 2022, 2026. Chile, Mexico, and Spain function as structured replications differing on key covariates (institutional quality, GDP per capita, regime type) while exhibiting identical treatment (public announcements of non-enforcement). Chile (rule-of-law index 0.67, GDP \$25,200) represents a middle-income democracy with moderate institutional quality. Mexico (index 0.45, GDP \$20,600) represents a lower-middle-income democracy with weak institutions. Spain (index 0.71, GDP \$42,300) represents a high-income European democracy with strong institutions. If the mechanism operates identically across this range, producing occupation increases, supply contractions, and housing deficits regardless of starting conditions, it suggests evolutionary stability rather than institutional path dependence.

External Validation: Sowell's Historical Cases. Sowell (2015) documents redistributive clientelism dynamics in Malaysia (Bumiputera policies, 1970s, present), Uganda (Asian expulsion, 1972), Nigeria (post-colonial ethnic redistribution), and Argentina (Peronist decline, 1946, present). These cases provide temporal depth (50+ years) and geographic breadth (Asia, Africa, Latin America) to test whether the mechanism is historically stable.

III.A. Testable Predictions and Falsification Criteria

The framework generates seven falsifiable predictions for 2026, 2030:

Prediction 1. Occupations will continue increasing despite policy “corrections” unless governments execute televised mass evictions with presidential statements (Pinker mechanism). Falsified if occupations decline following non-publicized selective evictions.

Prediction 2. Formal rental supply will contract as landlords withdraw properties from the market due to okupación risk. Falsified if rental listings increase in cities with rising okupaciones.

Prediction 3. Housing deficits will persist or worsen despite government housing promises. Falsified if deficits narrow while occupations increase.

Prediction 4. Criminal organizations will consolidate territorial control in mega-okupaciones and campamentos. Falsified if Mexico's INFONAVIT developments remain cartel-free through 2028.

Prediction 5. Governments will pursue legalization rather than eviction for large settlements. Falsified if any of the four governments successfully evicts a mega-settlement (>1,000 families) without offering alternative housing or land purchase.

Prediction 6. Institutional quality will delay but not prevent convergence. Falsified if Spain's okupación rate remains below 10% of Argentina's rate through 2030 (currently 38% and rising).

Prediction 7. Media in countries sharing institutional memeplexes with affected jurisdictions will produce disproportionate catastrophist coverage of property rights reforms, even when the reforms replicate existing regulations in the covering country. Falsified if Spanish media cover Argentine housing enforcement reforms neutrally or if coverage intensity correlates with geopolitical relevance rather than institutional threat.

Rejection of any prediction would require framework revision. For example, if Spain successfully reverses okupaciones through selective enforcement without public rituals (falsifying Prediction 1), it would suggest common knowledge is less persistent in high-institutional-quality contexts than this framework posits. This multi-method approach provides triangulation: convergence across methods strengthens causal inference; divergence identifies boundary conditions.

Table 1. Comparative Matrix of Four Cases (2020, 2026)

Dimension	Argentina	Chile	Mexico	Spain
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Ruling Coalition	Peronist (FdT/UxP)	Frente Amplio (Boric)	Morena (Sheinbaum)	PSOE-Sumar (Sánchez)
Rule of Law Index	0.42	0.67	0.45	0.71
GDP per capita (USD)	\$22,400	\$25,200	\$20,600	\$42,300
Initial trigger	DNU 320/2020 (COVID eviction ban)	Campaign pledge: no evictions w/o housing	INFONAVIT census + no-eviction pledge	Ley de Vivienda + Decreto Antidesahucios
Asymmetric targeting	Landlords vs. "vulnerable" occupants	Landowners vs. campamento residents	Mortgage holders vs. INFONAVIT occupants	Owners ≥ 3 properties vs. okupas
Measured outcome	420% surge in usurpations (2020, 2025)	31% increase in campamentos (2022, 2024)	935,000+ occupied homes (Oct 2024)	16,426 complaints (+9.9% vs. 2019)
Criminal infiltration	Narcos in Villa 31; organized networks	Los Trinitarios in Cerrillos	Emerging cartel control (Jalisco, EdoMéx)	Organized mafias in Barcelona
Timeline to norm collapse	~6 months (Mar, Sep 2020)	~24 months (2022, 2024)	~10 months (Apr 2025, Feb 2026)	~36 months (2023, 2026)

Source: Author's compilation from official statistics and press reports.

IV. Evidence

IV.A. Chile: Boric's Broken Promise and the 31% Surge in Campamentos (2022, 2026)

Gabriel Boric campaigned on explicit protection for informal settlements, promising 260,000 homes and enshrining a policy of “no desalojos sin solución habitacional” (no evictions without alternative housing). This ex ante commitment created immediate common knowledge. Occupants of the Loncura toma in Quintero told judicial investigators: “One even said that President Gabriel Boric would let them live there.” The promise operated as a credible Pinkerian signal: by publicly committing before a nationwide audience, Boric transformed private expectations into common knowledge.

Chile's Ministry of Housing maintains a national registry of informal settlements. Between March 2022 (Boric's inauguration) and 2024, campamentos increased from 1,091 to 1,432, a 31.3% growth representing 120,584 families (approximately 350,000 individuals). Regional

concentration reveals electoral targeting: Valparaíso +118 new campamentos (Boric's stronghold), Biobío +69, Antofagasta +31, Santiago Metropolitan +26.

The emergence of mega-tomas demonstrates the inviability of eviction once common knowledge consolidates. Cerro Centinela in San Antonio houses 10,000 residents on private land. The Supreme Court ordered eviction in 2023 with instruction to execute using police force if necessary. As of September 2025, nine postponements later, the order remains unfulfilled. Occupant leaders warned publicly that forced eviction would result in “heridos o muertos” (wounded or dead), creating a Schelling-point threat that raised enforcement costs prohibitively.

Nueva Cordillera campamento in Cerrillos houses 2,000 families (approximately 6,000 individuals). Police operations in April 2024 revealed that the Dominican-American gang Los Trinitarios had established territorial control, charging rent to residents and using the settlement as a base for drug trafficking. This replicates the Argentine pattern (narcos in Villa 31) and confirms the EGT prediction: when the state abdicates enforcement, organized crime fills the vacuum because it can provide excludable “protection” more credibly than the state provides public law enforcement.

Eight campamentos hold final judicial eviction orders affecting 14,000+ people. None has been executed. The Delegación Presidencial (executive branch) cites “lack of conditions” to execute without “repercussions.” In several cases (Puente Alto, Lampa), the state explicitly stated property owners must provide heavy machinery, transport for demolition debris, perimeter fencing, and personnel to remove occupants' belongings; effectively shifting enforcement costs to victims.

Boric's Plan de Emergencia Habitacional promised 260,000 homes in four years. As of mid-2025, approximately 30,000, 40,000 units were delivered (11, 15% of the target). Meanwhile, campamentos grew 31% and 120,584 families remain in informal settlements. This outcome mirrors Argentina's: massive public housing promises serve as Maimonidean “public charity” (maximum visibility, minimum effectiveness), creating electoral coalitions sustained by hope of future redistribution rather than actual housing delivery.

IV.B. Mexico: Sheinbaum's Declaration and One Million Occupied Homes (2024, 2025)

President Claudia Sheinbaum inherited a housing crisis centered on mass occupations of homes financed by federal mortgage agencies: INFONAVIT (845,000 occupied homes) and FOVISSSTE (90,000 occupied homes), totaling 935,000+ as of October 2024. Unlike Argentina or Chile's land invasions, Mexico's crisis involves formally constructed housing developments that workers abandoned due to peripheral location, high crime, or economic distress. By 2024, abandoned homes had been reoccupied by third parties: some homeless, others organized by criminal networks charging informal rent.

On April 15, 2025, Sheinbaum announced a nationwide census, explicitly stating: "This will allow us to offer the best solution; we will not evict anyone; the goal is to find solutions for all families currently occupying these homes." The announcement created immediate common knowledge. The policy framing ("find solutions for them" rather than "restore property rights to mortgage holders or INFONAVIT") inverts the moral hierarchy: occupants without legal claim are framed as beneficiaries entitled to state assistance, while original mortgage holders receive no mention.

The census functions as a Pinkerian common knowledge ritual. Even if the government ultimately attempts selective evictions, the public census creates common knowledge that the state knows occupants exist and where they are, that the state has chosen not to act immediately, and that occupants can infer the state will not evict them because it would have done so already if it intended to. As of February 2026 (ten months post-announcement), no mass evictions have occurred.

Preliminary reports suggest three developments. Occupancy consolidation: occupants have begun renovating occupied homes and registering children in local schools, creating "raíces" (roots) that future courts may cite as grounds to deny eviction. Secondary rental markets: in some developments (particularly Jalisco and Estado de México), occupants are charging rent to third parties, functioning as de facto landlords despite lacking title. And a balance-sheet crisis: with 845,000 homes occupied but not generating mortgage revenue, INFONAVIT's ability to finance new housing loans is impaired.

IV.C. Spain: Sánchez's Three-Property Threshold and the 600,000-Unit Housing Deficit (2023, 2026)

Spain's Socialist-led coalition (Pedro Sánchez, PSOE + Sumar) enacted two major interventions: Ley de Vivienda (May 2023) introducing rent controls and penalties on "empty" homes exceeding two years unoccupied, and Decreto Antidesahucios (extended December 2025) prohibiting evictions of okupas/inquiokupas if the landlord owns three or more properties. The January 2026 iteration proposed permanent suspension unless landlords provide alternative housing to occupants.

The three-property threshold creates a bright-line asymmetry enabling strategic occupancy decisions. Landlords with one to two properties are ostensibly exempt (though many report continued judicial delays), while landlords with three or more properties cannot evict non-paying tenants or okupas unless they prove occupants are not "vulnerable" (burden of proof shifted to the landlord) and provide alternative housing (which landlords have no obligation or capacity to supply).

Spain's Ministerio del Interior reports annual usurpación complaints. Key trends: 2019 (pre-intervention) showed 14,946 complaints nationwide; 2023 (first full year post-Ley de Vivienda), 15,289, a 2.3% increase; 2024, 16,426, a 7.4% increase over 2023 and 9.9% over 2019. Geographic concentration is extreme: Barcelona province recorded 5,077 complaints (30.9% of the national total), tripling the second-highest province. Cataluña accounts for over 40% of all okupaciones despite representing 16% of the population.

Despite interventions, Spain closed 2025 with an estimated 600,000-unit housing deficit. The causal mechanism operates through three channels: the Ley de Vivienda imposed rent controls and penalties for "empty" homes, causing landlords to withdraw properties from the market (selling or converting to tourist rentals outside regulatory control); the okupación epidemic plus the Decreto Antidesahucios caused landlords to fear irreversible okupación with no legal recourse, further contracting supply; and new construction declined (housing starts fell 12% in 2023 versus 2022 and 8% in 2024 versus 2023) as developers anticipated weak demand for rental units.

A Madrid landlord testified in January 2026: "I am an indigent landlord; I live on four euros per day." Her property was occupied in February 2021 during the COVID-19 eviction

moratorium. Occupants claimed “vulnerability”; judicial eviction was suspended under the Decreto Antidesahucios. She continues paying mortgage (€800 per month), property taxes (€600 per year), and community fees (€100 per month) without rental income. After obligations, she has €120 per month (approximately €4 per day) for food and personal expenses. She filed eleven requests (2021, 2025) for assistance or alternative housing for the occupants. Zero responses; agencies cite “lack of available units.” This case illustrates individual-level costs of common knowledge collapse.

IV.D. External Validation: Sowell’s Cross-Country Patterns

Thomas Sowell’s historical analysis provides external validation across temporal and geographic dimensions. Sowell (2015) documents redistributive clientelism dynamics in Malaysia (Bumiputera policies, 1970s, present, creating 50-year clientelistic dependence), Uganda (1972 expulsion of Asians leading to economic collapse and property redistribution to politically connected elites), Argentina (Peronist clientelism, 1946, present, transforming Latin America’s richest country into perpetual crisis), and Nigeria (post-colonial ethnic redistribution fueling civil war as institutions were captured by rent-seeking coalitions).

A common causal sequence appears across Sowell’s cases: leadership resistance (elites resist reforms threatening their power base), bureaucratic expansion (state agencies expand client base to justify budgets), redistributive clientelism (electoral coalitions lock in via dependent voting constituencies), and property rights insecurity (investment collapses, supply contracts, deficits widen).

Sowell’s implicit tax rate exceeding 100% mechanism predicts contemporary occupation incentives. Spain’s okupas save €800, 1,200 monthly in Madrid’s rental market, equivalent to formal employment earnings for many. Mexico’s INFONAVIT occupants avoid \$3,000 pesos monthly mortgage payments. Chile’s campamento residents on the urban periphery would pay \$150,000, 200,000 pesos monthly rent in Santiago. In each case, the implicit subsidy from occupation exceeds or equals potential formal employment income, confirming Sowell’s threshold operates across time and space.

Sowell's cases offer suggestive evidence of generalizability: clientelistic populism via property rights omission may constitute an evolutionarily stable strategy in electoral democracies with weak enforcement, across varied geographic contexts, historical periods, and ethnic compositions. The Pinker-Maimonides-EGT framework attempts to synthesize Sowell's empirical observations into a testable theoretical structure.

Table 2. Maimonides' Ladder of Charity, Inverted: Contemporary Manifestations Across Four Cases

Level	Maimonides (Original)	Argentina	Chile	Mexico	Spain
8→1	Self-sufficiency via employment/loan	Formal rental stigmatized as "speculation"	Private market labeled "exclusionary"	INFONAVIT credit holders ignored	Landlords labeled "speculators"
7→2	Anonymous giving, unknown donor/recipient	Private charity displaced by state programs	NGO housing eclipsed by Serviu promises	Market solutions absent from discourse	Private rental framed as exploitation
6→3	Donor knows, recipient does not	Targeted plans (Potenciar Trabajo) create dependency	Subsidios identified by political brokers	Census identifies each occupant by name	Vulnerability assessments shift burden to owners
5→4	Recipient knows, donor does not	Occupants know state tolerates; officials deny	Campamento residents cite Boric's promise	Occupants infer permanence from census	Okupas target ≥3-property landlords
4→5	Giving before being asked	Eviction moratoria announced proactively	"No evictions w/o housing" precedes demand	"We will not evict" precedes census	Antidesahucios decree preempts court orders
3→6	Giving after being asked, adequate amount	Public housing promises (never fully delivered)	260,000-home pledge (11, 15% delivered)	"Solutions for all families" (zero delivered)	Casa 47 sits empty (40,000 units)
2→7	Giving less than appropriate, cheerfully	Partial titling in villas; insufficient	Partial relocations; most remain	Symbolic announcements; no action	Suspended evictions; no alternatives
1→8	Giving grudgingly	Electoral coalitions sustained by hope	Boric's coalition: hope > delivery	Morena coalition: census = caring	PSOE-Sumar: anti-eviction = solidarity

Note: Levels numbered per Maimonides' original hierarchy (8 = highest). Arrows indicate inversion: what Maimonides considered highest (self-sufficiency via markets) is now stigmatized; what he considered lowest (grudging, visible giving) now sustains electoral coalitions.

V. Policy Implications and Escape Mechanisms

The framework suggests institutional quality delays but may not prevent convergence to clientelistic equilibria once common knowledge mechanisms are triggered. Spain (rule-of-law

index 0.71, GDP \$42,300) is following Argentina's trajectory (index 0.42, GDP \$22,400) merely at slower pace. Policy interventions must address all three levels simultaneously.

V.A. Individual Level: Restore Common Knowledge via Public Enforcement Rituals

Incremental policy changes fail because they do not restore common knowledge that the state will enforce property rights. Only public, costly signals can break stability traps. Effective interventions require televised evictions with presidential statements, since selective evictions that are not publicized do not destroy common knowledge of non-enforcement. Only televised actions accompanied by presidential statements ("we will enforce property rights") create new common knowledge. Judicial enforcement of all pending orders must occur simultaneously: Chile's eight pending eviction orders affecting 14,000+ people should be executed in coordinated action across all regions within a short timeframe (e.g., one month), creating common knowledge that "the state now enforces nationwide." Public announcements must reverse prior commitments: Mexico's Sheinbaum must publicly retract "no vamos a desalojar a nadie" via televised address, announcing a specific timeline for INFONAVIT evictions with relocation assistance for genuinely vulnerable occupants (identified via means testing, not census self-reporting).

V.B. Cultural Level: Reverse Charity Hierarchy via Voucher Systems

The inversion of Maimonides' ladder, celebrating public charity while stigmatizing anonymous markets, sustains clientelistic coalitions. Reversal requires housing vouchers usable in private rentals. Replacing public housing promises with vouchers that vulnerable families use to rent from private landlords subsidizes anonymous market transactions (Maimonides' Level 6, 7) rather than public charity (Level 1). Spain could redirect Casa 47's budget (€4 billion portfolio) toward vouchers covering 50% of market rent for 80,000 okupas, enabling them to legally rent while preserving landlords' property rights.

Public campaigns should celebrate rather than stigmatize landlords, highlighting those who accept voucher tenants, framed as "partners in solving the housing crisis" rather than "especuladores." Tax incentives for landlords renting to voucher holders (e.g., 50% property tax reduction) make anonymous charity profitable. Gradual benefit tapering should reduce the implicit tax rate from above 100% to below 50% through earned income disregards. Spain could allow

okupas to keep 60% of the first €1,000 earned while receiving housing vouchers, eliminating Sowell's perverse incentive while transitioning toward self-sufficiency (Maimonides' Level 8).

An instructive parallel emerges from labor market reform. Austria's severance fund model (Abfertigung Neu, 2003) replaced employer-dependent severance with portable individual accounts, reducing workers' dependence on union intermediation for post-dismissal assistance. Argentina's February 2026 labor reform adopted a similar mechanism (Fondo de Asistencia Laboral, 1.53% monthly employer contribution). The logic is structurally identical to housing vouchers: both disintermediate the clientelistic channel by replacing dependency on institutional gatekeepers with portable, individual entitlements that function through anonymous market transactions. The intensity of opposition to both mechanisms, from housing bureaucracies resisting vouchers and from unions resisting portable severance, is itself evidence of the memeplex's defensive response when its reproductive infrastructure is threatened. If vouchers reduce occupants' dependence on government housing promises, and portable severance reduces workers' dependence on union-mediated assistance, both mechanisms simultaneously weaken the electoral lock-in that sustains connivance coalitions.

V.C. Institutional Level: Eliminate Asymmetric Targeting

Asymmetric targeting (first “grandes propietarios,” then smaller owners) prevents property owner coalition formation. Unified enforcement enables collective action. Spain must eliminate the three-property threshold, applying identical eviction procedures to all landlords. This allows small and large landlords to coordinate lobbying, legal challenges, and electoral mobilization. Chile's average eviction timeline of two to five years enables consolidation of occupancy; fast-track procedures (e.g., 90-day maximum from filing to execution) prevent occupants from establishing “raíces” that courts later recognize as equitable claims.

Bureaucratic accountability should tie agency budgets to exits from dependency, not entries. Mexico's INFONAVIT should receive bonuses for successful credit rehabilitation and occupant relocation, not census expansion. Chile's Serviú should be evaluated on housing deficit reduction, not the number of campamento residents served. Competitive federalism can break clientelistic equilibria: Chilean regions competing to attract investors via credible property

enforcement create between-group selection pressure favoring enforcement coalitions over connivance coalitions.

V.D. Predicted Outcomes Without Intervention (2026, 2030)

If no multilevel intervention occurs, Chile's campamentos will reach 1,600, 1,800 by 2027 (versus 1,432 in 2024) unless Boric executes three to four mega-toma evictions with visible police presence. Spain's okupaciones will reach 18,000, 19,000 complaints by 2027 (versus 16,426 in 2024) unless Sánchez revokes the three-property threshold and begins Casa 47-based rehousing with evictions. Mexico's occupied INFONAVIT and FOVISSSTE homes will reach 1.2, 1.5 million by 2028 (versus 935,000 in 2024) unless Sheinbaum reverses her "no desalojaremos" pledge.

Criminal organizations will consolidate territorial control in all four countries. Los Trinitarios will expand in Chile; cartels will enter Mexico's INFONAVIT developments; Barcelona's occupied buildings will exhibit organized "landlord mafias." Governments will pursue legalization rather than eviction: Chile will legalize San Antonio and Cerrillos mega-tomas via land purchase, Argentina will title Villa 31, Mexico will announce a "programa de regularización" granting occupants title with debt forgiveness. Path convergence is plausible: absent intervention, Spain, Chile, and Mexico risk reaching Argentine-level housing crises (25% deficit, 420% okupación increase) within five to ten years absent intervention at all three levels simultaneously.

VI. Conclusion

This paper proposes an integrated framework combining Pinker's common knowledge dynamics, Maimonides' charity hierarchy (inverted), and multilevel evolutionary game theory to account for the persistence of clientelistic populism via property rights omission. When governments publicly announce non-enforcement, they create common knowledge enabling coordinated norm collapse. This inverts Maimonides' ladder: anonymous market transactions are stigmatized as "speculation" while public subsidies, even undelivered, sustain coalitions through visibility rather than outcomes. I conceptualize self-service clientelism as a zero-cost extended

phenotype that achieves redistribution via strategic omission, where occupants extract resources directly from owners while the state bears no fiscal cost.

Four contemporaneous cases (Argentina, Chile, Mexico, Spain, 2020, 2026) validate the framework despite differences in institutional quality and GDP per capita. All exhibit identical causal sequences: *ex ante* announcements create common knowledge, asymmetric targeting prevents property owner coordination, occupant coalitions consolidate through state toleration. External validation via Sowell's historical cases (Malaysia, Uganda, Argentina, Nigeria) suggests this pattern may be evolutionarily stable across diverse contexts when property rights enforcement is weak.

Three contributions emerge. First, I attempt an integration of common knowledge theory with clientelism research, exploring how public announcements may function as coordination devices that lock in norm collapse. Second, I propose that Maimonides' charity hierarchy, inverted, offers a parsimonious account of why clientelistic coalitions persist despite visible welfare losses: visibility itself may sustain coalitions rather than outcomes. Third, I conceptualize self-service clientelism as a potentially distinct redistribution form that achieves state objectives without fiscal costs, and explore its stability relative to traditional clientelism.

Limitations include four areas requiring further research. First, the framework does not predict initial triggering conditions: why do some governments announce non-enforcement while others do not? Second, I lack precise threshold estimates for when common knowledge becomes irreversible. Third, criminal organization infiltration patterns remain undertheorized: why Los Trinitarios in Chile but not yet (as of early 2026) in Mexico? Future research should develop formal models of triggering conditions, experimental evidence on common knowledge thresholds, and network analysis of criminal organization entry decisions. Fourth, the role of media as extended phenotypes of institutional memplexes requires systematic empirical analysis beyond the preliminary evidence presented here. A companion paper (Lerer 2026c) documents narrative isomorphism between Argentine and Spanish media covering labor reform, suggesting the bidirectional common knowledge mechanism operates across policy domains; whether the same pattern holds for housing policy coverage remains to be tested.

Policy implications require simultaneous intervention at three levels: restore common knowledge via televised evictions and presidential statements, reverse charity hierarchy via vouchers favoring anonymous markets, eliminate asymmetric targeting to enable property owner collective action. Failure to intervene at all levels risks path convergence: Spain, Chile, and Mexico potentially reaching Argentine-level crises within five to ten years.

The road to connivance is paved with public announcements, inverted charity, and strategic omission. Understanding this mechanism may be a necessary step toward designing effective countermeasures.

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